

SoFi Stadium Workers Authorize Strike Days Before World Cup Kickoff

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Just days before the U.S. men's national team takes on Paraguay in the first American match of the 2026 World Cup, a labor dispute threatens to disrupt the event. Workers at SoFi Stadium in Inglewood, California including cashiers, concession workers, bartenders, dishwashers, cooks, and food attendants voted overwhelmingly, 96%, to authorize a strike. Their union, **UNITE HERE Local 11**, announced the vote on Friday, warning that "workers could walk off the job at any moment if their demands are not met." The demands are twofold: higher wages and job security, but also a unique and urgent concern protection from federal immigration enforcement. Under the Trump administration's aggressive immigration crackdown, workers fear that U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (**ICE**) and **Border Patrol** agents could be present at the games, potentially separating families. Union member Yolanda Fierro captured the anxiety: "Fans from around the world will come expecting an unforgettable event, and we take pride in making that happen. But no worker should have to fear being separated from their family or worry about dangerous **ICE** activity while simply doing their job." The union has asked FIFA to demand that **ICE** and **Border Patrol** play no role at the World Cup. The situation is complicated. LA County Sheriff Robert Luna said he was told by a local Department of Homeland Security official that federal agents would be present for security but would not conduct immigration enforcement. However, DHS Acting Assistant Secretary Lauren Bis would not confirm that, stating only that the department would secure the event "in line with federal law." Meanwhile, **ICE** has posted on social media that its agents will combat **human trafficking** and **counterfeit merchandise**. Legends Global, the hospitality manager, says it has a "strong relationship" with the union and is committed to "**good faith negotiations**." Talks are set to continue Monday. With the world watching, the outcome could set a precedent for how major sporting events balance labor rights, security, and immigration policy.

Word Treasure

UNITE HERE Local 11 -- UNITE HERE Local 11 is a labor union that represents hospitality workers, like those in hotels, stadiums, and restaurants, in Southern California.

ICE -- ICE stands for U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement, the federal agency that enforces immigration laws inside the country.

Border Patrol -- U.S. Border Patrol is a law enforcement agency that guards the country's borders and can also perform immigration checks inside the territory.

counterfeit merchandise -- Counterfeit merchandise means fake goods that are illegally made to look like official products, such as fake World Cup jerseys and souvenirs.

human trafficking -- Human trafficking is the illegal trade of people for forced labor or exploitation, often happening at large events.

good faith negotiations -- Good faith negotiations means both sides in a dispute genuinely try to reach a fair agreement, without tricking or misleading each other.

Background you need

SoFi Stadium in Inglewood, California, opened in 2020 and is one of the most expensive sports venues ever built, hosting the Los Angeles Rams and Chargers as well as events like Super Bowl LVI in 2022. Large sporting events typically rely on thousands of low-wage service workers, many of whom are immigrants, and labor disputes at stadiums are not unusual. UNITE HERE, the parent union, has a history of staging high-profile strikes at hotels and convention centers. The 2026 World Cup will be the first men's tournament hosted by three nations -- the U.S., Mexico, and Canada -- and is expected to generate billions of dollars. Under the Trump administration, federal immigration enforcement has become more aggressive, including worksite raids, which has heightened fear among immigrant communities. This dispute therefore merges two powerful forces: the labor rights movement and the national debate over immigration policy.

Break it down

LEAD: A labor dispute at SoFi Stadium threatens to disrupt the first U.S. match of the 2026 World Cup.

+ specific: Workers voted 96% to authorize a strike.

UNION AND WORKERS: UNITE HERE Local 11 represents cashiers, cooks, bartenders, and others, and warns they 'could walk off the job at any moment'.

+ DEMANDS: Higher wages, job security, and protection from federal immigration enforcement.

+ FEAR: Worker Yolanda Fierro expresses anxiety about ICE separating families.

UNION'S REQUEST TO FIFA: Ask for ICE and Border Patrol to have no role at the World Cup.

CONFLICTING OFFICIAL SIGNALS: Sheriff Luna says he was told federal agents would be there only for security, but DHS Acting Assistant Secretary won't confirm.

+ ICE's STATED ROLE: Combat human trafficking and counterfeit merchandise (via social media).

+ LAW ENFORCEMENT GAP: No clear promise that immigration enforcement won't happen.

HOSPITALITY MANAGER RESPONSE: Legends Global says it has a 'strong relationship' with the union and is in 'good faith negotiations'.

NEXT STEP: Talks are set to continue Monday, with a potential precedent for major event labor relations at stake.

Why it matters

This dispute shows how the people who make huge events like the World Cup possible -- often working behind the scenes -- have their own battles. For teenagers, it reveals the hidden tensions between global celebration and local justice, where workers' rights, immigration fears, and security collide.

Test what you remember

1. What percentage of workers at SoFi Stadium voted to authorize a strike?
 - (A) 50%
 - (B) 76%
 - (C) 88%
 - (D) 96%
2. Which union represents the SoFi Stadium workers?
 - (A) Teamsters Local 11
 - (B) SEIU Local 11
 - (C) UNITE HERE Local 11
 - (D) AFL-CIO Local 11
3. Apart from higher wages and job security, what unique demand did the workers make?
 - (A) Free transportation to the stadium
 - (B) Protection from federal immigration enforcement
 - (C) Access to VIP seating
 - (D) Extra vacation days during the World Cup
4. What did LA County Sheriff Robert Luna say about ICE's role?
 - (A) ICE would handle all security at the event
 - (B) ICE agents would conduct immigration enforcement at the stadium
 - (C) He was told federal agents would be present for security but not for immigration enforcement
 - (D) ICE would be banned from the stadium completely
5. What did ICE post on social media about the World Cup?
 - (A) That it would not be present at the event
 - (B) That its agents would combat human trafficking and counterfeit merchandise
 - (C) That it would only check documents of workers
 - (D) That it would provide water and snacks to fans
6. Who is the hospitality manager for the event, according to the article?
 - (A) FIFA
 - (B) SoFi Stadium management
 - (C) Legends Global
 - (D) Delaware North

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: B 4: C 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Positive / worker solidarity: The strike vote gives low-wage workers a powerful voice just before the world's biggest sporting event, forcing employers and FIFA to address their safety and dignity. It demonstrates how collective action can spotlight issues like immigration enforcement that are often ignored.

2. Negative / critical: A strike or even the threat of one could disrupt matches, hurt the fan experience, and tarnish the image of the United States as a host. Some may argue that security concerns, including human trafficking, are real and that ICE's presence is necessary to keep people safe.

3. Neutral / analytical: The conflict reflects a structural tension in the modern event economy: mega-events demand a flexible, often immigrant workforce, but the same workers are vulnerable to the very enforcement agencies that are part of the security apparatus. No easy policy balance has emerged between labor rights and federal law.

4. **Forward-looking:** The outcome of these negotiations could set a precedent for other 2026 host cities and future mega-events. If the union wins strong immigration-related protections, it may become a template for how large spectacles handle the intersection of hospitality work and enforcement policy.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):